

Incident Alert: 0034 TLP: CLEAR			Date	Breakout Scale
Title	EU	Sanctioned but Thriving: How Online Platforms Fail To Address the Widespread Presence of Entities Under EU Sanction	02/12/2024	4

Summary

- 250 cases of sanctioned Russian entities and systematic amplifiers of these entities were reported to X, TikTok, Google, Telegram, and Meta between June and October 2024. Excluding TikTok (which acted on all flags), 83% of the accounts of sanctioned entities or individuals reported remain accessible in the EU.
- Across platforms, further searches yielded 370 Russian and 90 Belarusian previously unreported new cases of official accounts of sanctioned entities or amplifiers of content from sanctioned entities being accessible in the EU.
- Many amplifier accounts, as well as a number of officially sanctioned accounts, appear to benefit from some platforms' monetization programs, notably ad-revenue sharing (Telegram, YouTube) or subscription (Facebook).
- Our analysis found a myriad of easily detectable techniques used to circumvent the sanctions.
- The channels remaining online after our initial flagging have 13,5 million followers while the newly identified channels have over 26 million followers.
- Stronger regulatory action is needed to ensure compliance and prevent economic support to sanctioned entities.

Incident

Between June and October 2024, we published five reports highlighting around 250 violations of EU sanctions against Russia on the platforms of Meta, Google, X/Twitter, TikTok, and Telegram. 83% of previously flagged accounts remain accessible (excluding TikTok, which acted fully), and 48% of amplifying accounts are still active, reaching millions within the EU. Additionally, 370 new cases of sanctioned content or amplifiers were found, with some benefiting from platform monetization.

Overall, given the ease with which such illegal content was discovered, Meta, Google, X/Twitter, TikTok and Telegram's compliance teams should investigate why they seem not to have taken sufficient action to limit access.

Council Regulation No. 269/2014 prohibits hosting content from these channels or making their content available to EU audiences on social media platforms, as clarified in Commission guidance updated mid-May 2024.

Narrative

N/A

Impact

The previously flagged pages had a total of 13.5 million followers. The newly discovered Russian and Belarusian cases are followed by 23 and 3.8 million followers respectively.

Key Objectives and Behaviours (DISARM Red Framework)

Objective: [Facilitate State Propaganda](#): The channels are all being used to spread Russian influence operation content;

[Generate Ad Revenue](#): Some of the pages are generating revenue through ads.

[Remove Post Origins](#): Pages trying to launder sanctioned content re-framed videos to remove sanctioned media logos;

[Domain Asset](#): Alternative domains were used to allow users to access the sanctioned websites.

[Bypass Content Blocking](#): Using unofficial yet affiliated channels such as journalists to promote operational content.

Recommendations and Actions Taken

Action taken: Sent the report to EU and EU member state regulators working on the issue; Flagged the issue to the mentioned social media platforms.

Civil society organisations across Europe are well placed to systematically monitor and report sanction violations. A coordinated effort supported by regulators would allow for better enforcement.

Report	Topic	Evidence	Authors	Content type	Platforms
Link	Sanctions	See report and Hunchly upon request.	Charles Terroille, Science Feedback, Kateryna Chystoforova, Science Feedback Saman Nazari, Alliance4Europe.	Accounts, videos, images, text	Telegram, TikTok, Meta, X, Google,